

# Synthesis Matrix

## CFAN 3091V | Week 8 Monday Workshop

**Name:** \_\_\_\_\_ **Date:** \_\_\_\_\_

**Source-set rationale.** Before any rows: what question this set of sources can answer, and what your search boundaries mean it cannot represent. The second sentence is what makes your gap claim defensible instead of absolute.

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| Source | Research question | Population or system | Method | Principal finding | Limitation | Relevance to your project | Relationship to other sources |
|--------|-------------------|----------------------|--------|-------------------|------------|---------------------------|-------------------------------|
|        |                   |                      |        |                   |            |                           |                               |
|        |                   |                      |        |                   |            |                           |                               |
|        |                   |                      |        |                   |            |                           |                               |
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|        |                   |                      |        |                   |            |                           |                               |
|        |                   |                      |        |                   |            |                           |                               |
|        |                   |                      |        |                   |            |                           |                               |

Write “not reported” where the paper does not answer the question. Do not infer a value to make a row look complete. Continue on a second copy, or build the same columns in a spreadsheet, whichever you will actually keep using.

## The Five Decision Rules

Use the same rules on every row.

1. Record the paper's claim in language no stronger than its design permits.
2. Separate a different result from a different population, measure, definition, or method. Those are not interchangeable disagreements.
3. Mark "not reported" when the paper does not answer a matrix question.
4. Put sources in the same theme only when you can name the shared question or concept.
5. Treat a gap as bounded by the Search Record. "I did not find" is not the same claim as "no research exists."

## Two or Three Themes That Could Organize Your Review

For each, name the shared question or concept, then list the source rows that belong to it. A theme you cannot state as a shared question is not a theme yet.

**Theme 1, and the sources in it:**

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**Theme 2, and the sources in it:**

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**Theme 3, if you have one:**

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## The Disagreement You Will Write About

**The two or more sources that do not agree:** \_\_\_\_\_

**What exactly differs.** Check the columns before you answer. ☐ the finding ☐ the population ☐ the measure ☐ the definition ☐ the method

**Why that difference matters for your question:**

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## The Gap, Bounded

Within the boundaries of my Search Record, what I did not locate:

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What my search could not have found, given where and how I searched:

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## Have You Read Enough?

Sketch the paper you have not written yet. Rough is fine. Committing to an answer is not optional.

**Table 1**, weather or method timeline. What it would have to contain: \_\_\_\_\_

**Table 2**, model statistics. The model your design implies: \_\_\_\_\_

**Figure 1**. Response variable: \_\_\_\_\_ Treatments or cases on it: \_\_\_\_\_

**Your ranking of those treatments or cases**, in the order you expect:

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**Why that order and not another one.** This is the answer that decides whether you have read enough.

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**The one place in that ranking you could not defend:** \_\_\_\_\_

That is your next search. Not “read more,” but that.

## Sentence Check

Every sentence in a literature review does one of four jobs. Label each sentence of your drafted paragraph, then count.

☐ 1. Reports what one source found      ☐ 2. Puts two or more sources in relation      ☐ 3. States what that relation means for your question      ☐ 4. Names what it leaves unsettled

**Count of each in your paragraph:** 1: \_\_\_\_\_ 2: \_\_\_\_\_ 3: \_\_\_\_\_ 4: \_\_\_\_\_

If nearly all of them are job 1, you have written a summary. That is a finding about the draft, and it is fixable before Wednesday.